

Question ID: de55ec71

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	Easy

Question

Generations of mystery and horror _____ have been influenced by the dark, gothic stories of celebrated American author Edgar Allan Poe (1809–1849).

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. writers
- B. writers,
- C. writers—
- D. writers;

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer. The convention being tested is punctuation between a subject and a verb. When, as in this case, a subject (“Generations of mystery and horror writers”) is immediately followed by a verb (“have been influenced”), no punctuation is needed.

Choice B is incorrect because no punctuation is needed between the subject and the verb. Choice C is incorrect because no punctuation is needed between the subject and the verb. Choice D is incorrect because no punctuation is needed between the subject and the verb.

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	Medium

Question

Since the nineteenth century, Egyptologists have commonly divided ancient Egyptian history into three primary _____ Old Kingdom (2700–2200 BCE), the Middle Kingdom (2050–1800 BCE), and the New Kingdom (1550–1100 BCE). Some historians, however, criticize the names of these periods for revealing more about the culture of the mainly European Egyptologists than that of ancient Egypt itself.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. periods. The
- B. periods: the
- C. periods; the
- D. periods, the

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer. The convention being tested is punctuation use between a main clause and an enumerated series. In this choice, a colon is correctly used after the main clause (“Since...periods”) to introduce the series identifying the three primary periods of ancient Egyptian history.

Choice A is incorrect because placing a period after “periods” results in a rhetorically unacceptable sentence fragment beginning with “the Old Kingdom.” Choice C is incorrect because a semicolon can’t be used in this way to introduce a series. A semicolon is conventionally used to join two main clauses or to separate items in a complex series, neither of which is the case here. Choice D is incorrect because a comma is not conventionally used to mark the boundary between the main clause (“Since...periods”) and an enumerated series (“the Old Kingdom...(1550–1100 BCE)”) that contains internal commas. Using a comma in this way creates ambiguity about which commas separate elements in the series and which mark other boundaries in the sentence, making the colon the best choice.

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	Medium

Question

The Mission 66 initiative, which was approved by Congress in 1956, represented a major investment in the infrastructure of overburdened national ____ it prioritized physical improvements to the parks’ roads, utilities, employee housing, and visitor facilities while also establishing educational programming for the public.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. parks and
- B. parks
- C. parks;
- D. parks,

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer. The convention being tested is the coordination of main clauses within a sentence. This choice uses a semicolon to correctly join the first main clause (“The Mission...parks”) and the second main clause that begins with “it.”

Choice A is incorrect. When coordinating two longer main clauses such as these, it’s conventional to use a comma before the coordinating conjunction. Choice B is incorrect because it results in a run-on sentence. The two main clauses are fused without punctuation and/or a conjunction. Choice D is incorrect because it results in a comma splice. Without a conjunction following it, a comma can’t be used in this way to join two main clauses.

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	Hard

Question

A recent study tracked the number of bee species present in twenty-seven New York apple orchards over a ten-year period. _____ found that when wild growth near an orchard was cleared, the number of different bee species visiting the orchard decreased.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. Entomologist Heather Grab:
- B. Entomologist, Heather Grab,
- C. Entomologist Heather Grab
- D. Entomologist Heather Grab,

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer. The convention being tested is punctuation use between a name and title and between a subject and a verb. No punctuation is needed between the proper noun “Heather Grab” and “entomologist,” the title that describes Grab. Additionally, no punctuation is needed between the sentence’s subject (“Entomologist Heather Grab”) and the main verb (“found”) that indicates what Grab did.

Choice A is incorrect because no punctuation is needed between the subject and the verb. Choice B is incorrect because no punctuation is needed. Setting the entomologist’s name off with commas suggests that it could be removed without affecting the coherence of the sentence, which isn’t the case. Choice D is incorrect because no punctuation is needed between the subject and the verb.

Question ID: 4b0c7b62

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	Easy

Question

The algaita is a double reed wind instrument from West Africa. The reed of a wind instrument is the mouthpiece _____. A double reed contains two pieces of cane that vibrate and produce sound as air passes between them.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. where sound is made?
- B. where is sound made.
- C. where sound is made.
- D. where is sound made?

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer. The convention being tested is end-of-sentence punctuation. This choice correctly uses a period to punctuate a declarative sentence ("the reed of a wind instrument is the mouthpiece") that ends with a prepositional phrase ("where sound is made").

Choice A is incorrect. It's unconventional to use a question mark to punctuate a declarative sentence. Choice B is incorrect. The structure requires that the sentence continue as a declarative clause, not end with an interrogative clause. Choice D is incorrect. The structure requires that the sentence continue as a declarative clause and end with a period, not end with an interrogative clause and a question mark.

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	Medium

Question

In a 2023 study, researchers documented a fascinating behavior in the aquatic plant *Elodea densa*. When exposed to low levels of light, the plant’s _____ the cellular organs that generate energy from light—reshuffled to form a tightly packed, glass-like surface ideal for collecting more light.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. chloroplasts
- B. chloroplasts;
- C. chloroplasts,
- D. chloroplasts—

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. The convention being tested is the punctuation of a supplementary element within a sentence. The dash after "chloroplasts" pairs with the dash after "from light" to separate the supplementary element "the cellular organs that generate energy from light" from the rest of the sentence. This supplementary element functions to define the term "chloroplasts," and the pair of dashes indicates that this element could be removed without affecting the grammatical coherence of the sentence.

Choice A is incorrect because it fails to use appropriate punctuation to separate the supplementary element from the rest of the sentence. Choice B is incorrect because a semicolon can’t be paired with a dash in this way to separate the supplementary element from the rest of the sentence. Choice C is incorrect because a comma can’t be paired with a dash in this way to separate the supplementary element from the rest of the sentence.

Question ID: 74ce2f05

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	Medium

Question

A study led by scientist Rebecca Kirby at the University of Wisconsin–Madison found that black bears that eat human food before hibernation have increased levels of a rare carbon isotope, _____ due to the higher ¹³C levels in corn and cane sugar. Bears with these elevated levels were also found to have much shorter hibernation periods on average.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. carbon-13, (¹³C)
- B. carbon-13 (¹³C)
- C. carbon-13, (¹³C),
- D. carbon-13 (¹³C),

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. The convention being tested is the punctuation of a supplementary element within a sentence. The comma after “(13C)” pairs with the comma after “isotope” to separate the supplementary element “carbon-13 (13C)” from the rest of the sentence. This supplementary element defines the “rare carbon isotope,” and the pair of commas indicates that this element could be removed without affecting the grammatical coherence of the sentence.

Choice A is incorrect because it fails to use appropriate punctuation to separate the supplementary element “carbon-13 (13C)” from the rest of the sentence. Choice B is incorrect because it fails to use appropriate punctuation to separate the supplementary element “carbon-13 (13C)” from the rest of the sentence. Choice C is incorrect because it fails to use appropriate punctuation to separate the supplementary element “carbon-13 (13C)” from the rest of the sentence. The comma after “carbon-13” isn’t necessary because the parentheses around “13C” already separate this element from the rest of the sentence.

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	Easy

Question

Researchers Amit Kumar and Nicholas Epley investigated how _____. In a series of experiments conducted in 2022, they found that people performing small acts of kindness underestimated the positive effect their actions had on others.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. do people perceive acts of kindness.
- B. do people perceive acts of kindness?
- C. people perceive acts of kindness?
- D. people perceive acts of kindness.

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. The convention being tested is end-of-sentence punctuation. This choice correctly uses a period to punctuate a declarative sentence that asks an indirect question ("Researchers Amit Kumar and Nicholas Epley investigated how people perceive acts of kindness").

Choice A is incorrect. The structure of the sentence requires a declarative clause at the end of the sentence that states what Kumar and Epley did, not an interrogative clause that asks a direct question, such as "how do people perceive acts of kindness." Choice B is incorrect. The structure of the sentence requires a declarative clause at the end of the sentence that states what Kumar and Epley did, not an interrogative clause that asks a direct question, such as "how do people perceive acts of kindness?" Choice C is incorrect. It's unconventional to use a question mark in this way to punctuate a declarative sentence that asks an indirect question, such as "Researchers...kindness."

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	Hard

Question

The Limón technique, developed by Mexican-born dancer and choreographer Jose Limón, is known for its emphasis on breath control and its interplay of weight and _____ dancers may explore, for example, the moment of mid-air suspension at the top of a jump.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. weightlessness
- B. weightlessness which
- C. weightlessness,
- D. weightlessness;

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. The convention being tested is the use of punctuation within a sentence. This choice uses a semicolon in a conventional way to join the first main clause ("The Limón...weightlessness") and the second main clause ("dancers...jump").

Choice A is incorrect because it results in a run-on sentence. The two main clauses are fused without punctuation and/or a conjunction. Choice B is incorrect. The relative pronoun "which" can't be used in this way to join two main clauses. Choice C is incorrect because it results in a comma splice. Without a conjunction following it, a comma can't be used in this way to join two main clauses.

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	Hard

Question

The haiku-like poems of Tomas Tranströmer, which present nature- and dream-influenced images in crisp, spare language, have earned the Swedish poet praise from leading contemporary _____ them Nigerian American essayist and novelist Teju Cole, who has written that Tranströmer’s works “contain a luminous simplicity.”

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. writers. Among
- B. writers among
- C. writers; among
- D. writers, among

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. The convention being tested is punctuation use between a main clause and a supplementary phrase. This choice correctly uses a comma to mark the boundary between the main clause (“The haiku-like...writers”) and the supplementary phrase (“among... Cole”) that specifies a contemporary writer who has praised Tomas Tranströmer’s haiku-like poems.

Choice A is incorrect because it results in a rhetorically unacceptable sentence fragment beginning with “among.” Choice B is incorrect because it fails to mark the boundary between the main clause and the supplementary phrase with appropriate punctuation. Choice C is incorrect because a semicolon can’t be used in this way to join the main clause (“The haiku-like...writers”) and the supplementary phrase (“among...Cole”).

Question ID: 707461d8

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	Hard

Question

In 2021, Mexican biologist Martha Lydia Macías-Rubalcava led a review of the scientific literature related to endophytic fungi (i.e., fungi that live inside a host _____ researching 120 endophytic fungi–produced compounds, she found that their phytotoxicity can make them viable alternatives to chemical herbicides for controlling weeds.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. plant). By
- B. plant), by
- C. plant) and by
- D. plant) by

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer. The convention being tested is punctuation use between sentences. In this choice, the period is used correctly to mark the boundary between one sentence ("In...plant") and another ("By...weeds"). The prepositional phrase beginning with "by" modifies the subject of the next sentence, "she," which refers to Macías-Rubalcava.

Choice B is incorrect because it results in a comma splice. A comma can't be used in this way to join two sentences. Choice C is incorrect. Without a comma preceding it, the conjunction "and" can't be used in this way to join two sentences. Choice D is incorrect because it results in a run-on sentence. The two sentences are fused without punctuation and/or a conjunction.

Question ID: 13fcf575

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	Hard

Question

Roughly 300 nights a year, when the cold air descending from the Andes Mountains meets the warm air rising from Venezuela’s coastal Lake Maracaibo, the result is a spectacular lightning storm, its strikes so bright, so localized, and so _____ that it has become known as “Maracaibo’s Lighthouse.”

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. dependable:
- B. dependable;
- C. dependable
- D. dependable,

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer. The convention being tested is the punctuation of an integrated relative clause. No punctuation is needed before the relative clause beginning with "that" because the content of the relative clause ("that...Lighthouse") is integral to the meaning of the coordinated adjectival phrase ("so bright, so localized, and so dependable") that it modifies.

Choice A is incorrect because no punctuation is needed between the coordinated adjectival phrase ("so bright...dependable") and the integrated relative clause that modifies it. Choice B is incorrect because no punctuation is needed between the coordinated adjectival phrase ("so bright...dependable") and the integrated relative clause that modifies it. Choice D is incorrect because no punctuation is needed between the coordinated adjectival phrase ("so bright...dependable") and the integrated relative clause that modifies it.

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	Hard

Question

Jamaican British artist Willard Wigan is known for his remarkable _____ so small that they are best viewed through a microscope, Wigan’s sculptures are made from tiny natural materials, such as spiderweb strands.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. microsculptures creations
- B. microsculptures, creations
- C. microsculptures. Creations
- D. microsculptures and creations

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer. The convention being tested is punctuation between sentences. In this choice, the period is used to correctly mark the boundary between one sentence ("Jamaican...microsculptures") and another ("Creations...strands"). The noun phrase beginning with "creations" modifies the subject of the next sentence, "Wigan’s sculptures."

Choice A is incorrect because it results in a run-on sentence. The sentences ("Jamaican...microsculptures" and "Creations...strands") are fused without punctuation and/or a conjunction. Choice B is incorrect because it results in a comma splice. A comma can’t be used in this way to mark the boundary between sentences. Choice D is incorrect. Without a comma preceding it, the conjunction "and" can’t be used in this way to join sentences.

Question ID: 333b2b65

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	Medium

Question

While one requires oxygen and one does _____ and anaerobic respiration are both forms of cellular respiration—that is, they are processes by which cells break down glucose to use as energy.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. not aerobic
- B. not. Aerobic
- C. not, aerobic
- D. not; aerobic

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer. A comma is the appropriate way to link the dependent clause “While...not” and the independent clause that follows.

Choice A is incorrect. This choice creates a run-on sentence error. “While...not” is a dependent clause, which must be separated from the independent clause that follows with some sort of punctuation. Choice B is incorrect. This choice creates a sentence fragment. “While one requires oxygen and one does not” isn’t an independent clause, so it can’t stand alone as a complete sentence. Choice D is incorrect. This choice creates a punctuation error. “While one requires oxygen and one does not” isn’t an independent clause, so it can’t be linked to the clause that follows with a semicolon.

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	Hard

Question

To serve local families during the Great Depression, innovative New York City librarian Pura Belpré offered storytelling in both English and Spanish, an uncommon _____ celebrated *el Día de los Tres Reyes Magos*, an important community holiday; and put on puppet shows dramatizing Puerto Rican folktales.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. practice, at the time
- B. practice at the time;
- C. practice, at the time,
- D. practice at the time,

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer. The convention being tested is the punctuation of elements in a complex series. It’s conventional to use a semicolon to separate items in a complex series with internal punctuation, and in this choice, the semicolon after "time" is conventionally used to separate the first item ("offered...time") and the second ("celebrated...holiday") in the series of activities that librarian Pura Belpré offered. Moreover, the semicolon after "time" matches the semicolon used later to separate the second item ("celebrated...holiday") and the third ("and...folktales") in the series.

Choice A is incorrect because it fails to use appropriate punctuation to separate the first item and the second item in the complex series. Furthermore, a comma isn’t needed between the noun "practice" and the prepositional phrase "at the time" because the prepositional phrase is essential to the full meaning of the phrase "an uncommon practice at the time." Choice C is incorrect because a comma after "time" doesn’t match the semicolon used later to separate the second ("celebrated...holiday") and third ("and...folktales") items in the series. Furthermore, a comma isn’t needed between the noun "practice" and the prepositional phrase "at the time" because the prepositional phrase is essential to the full meaning of the phrase "an uncommon practice at the time." Choice D is incorrect because a comma after "time" doesn’t match the semicolon used later to separate the second ("celebrated...holiday") and third ("and...folktales") items in the series.

Question ID: 7f48b098

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	Medium

Question

Photosynthesis, the mechanism by which plants use sunlight to turn carbon dioxide and water into _____ is fueled in part by an enzyme called Photosystem II that harvests energy-giving electrons from water molecules.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. nutrients
- B. nutrients and
- C. nutrients,
- D. nutrients—

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer. The convention being tested is the punctuation of a supplementary element within a sentence. The comma after “nutrients” pairs with the comma after “photosynthesis” to separate the supplementary element “the mechanism by which plants use sunlight to turn carbon dioxide and water into nutrients” from the rest of the sentence. This supplementary element functions to define the term “photosynthesis,” and the pair of commas indicates that this element could be removed without affecting the grammatical coherence of the sentence.

Choice A is incorrect because it fails to use appropriate punctuation to separate the supplementary element from the rest of the sentence. Choice B is incorrect because a conjunction can’t be paired with a comma in this way to separate the supplementary element from the rest of the sentence. Choice D is incorrect because a dash can’t be paired with a comma in this way to separate the supplementary element from the rest of the sentence.

Question ID: 626a1642

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	Hard

Question

As a behavioral economist, Katy Milkman of the University of Pennsylvania recognizes that people sometimes make irrational economic decisions. Milkman’s research can thus address anomalies that neoclassical economic _____ assume that people are consistently rational decision-makers—cannot explain.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. models—which
- B. models, which
- C. models which
- D. models which—

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer. The convention being tested is the use of punctuation within a sentence. The dashes after "models" and "decision-makers" correctly separate the supplementary element "which assume that people are consistently rational decision-makers" from the rest of the sentence. This punctuation indicates that this element could be removed without affecting the grammatical coherence of the sentence.

Choice B is incorrect because a comma can’t be paired with a dash in this way to separate the supplementary element from the rest of the sentence. Choice C is incorrect because it fails to use appropriate punctuation to separate the supplementary element from the rest of the sentence. Choice D is incorrect because it interrupts the sentence at an illogical and grammatically incoherent point. The dash should be placed before "which," not after it, to mark the beginning of the supplementary element.

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	Easy

Question

Human-made (synthetic) fibers used in clothes and many other consumer products are more durable than most natural plant ____ the manufacture of synthetic fibers requires toxic chemical solvents that can pollute air and water.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. fibers,
- B. fibers but
- C. fibers
- D. fibers, but

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. The convention being tested is the coordination of main clauses within a sentence. This choice correctly uses a comma and the coordinating conjunction “but” to join the first main clause (“Human-made...fibers”) and the second main clause (“the manufacture...water”).

Choice A is incorrect because it results in a comma splice. Without a conjunction following it, a comma can’t be used in this way to join two main clauses. Choice B is incorrect because when coordinating two longer main clauses such as these, it’s conventional to use a comma before the coordinating conjunction. Choice C is incorrect because it results in a run-on sentence. The two main clauses are fused without punctuation and/or a conjunction.

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	Medium

Question

After a spate of illnesses as a child, Wilma Rudolph was told she might never walk again. Defying all odds, Rudolph didn't just walk, she _____ the 1960 Summer Olympics in Rome, she won both the 100- and 200-meter dashes and clinched first place for her team in the 4x100-meter relay, becoming the first US woman to win three gold medals in a single Olympics.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. ran—fast—during
- B. ran—fast during
- C. ran—fast, during
- D. ran—fast. During

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. The convention being tested is punctuation use between sentences. In this choice, the period is used correctly to mark the boundary between one sentence ("Defying...fast") and another sentence that begins with a supplementary phrase ("During...Olympics").

Choice A is incorrect. When a dash is present in a sentence ("ran—fast"), it's not conventional to use another dash ("fast—during") to mark the boundary between sentences because it creates a potentially confusing sentence. In this context, a period, semicolon, or colon would be clear and more conventional. Choice B is incorrect because it results in a run-on sentence. The sentences ("Defying...fast") and ("during...Olympics") are fused without punctuation and/or a conjunction. Choice C is incorrect because it results in a comma splice. A comma can't be used in this way to mark the boundary between sentences.

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	Hard

Question

Recent analysis of 32532 Thereus—an outer solar system object orbiting the Sun between Jupiter and Saturn—has determined its color to be gray, suggesting an icy composition. Such interpretations are ultimately _____ the object’s gray coloration may be an incidental effect of radiation, solar wind, or collisions with other objects rather than evidence of its physical makeup.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. speculative, though
- B. speculative, though;
- C. speculative; though
- D. speculative, though,

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer. The convention being tested is the use of punctuation in a sentence. This choice correctly uses a comma to separate the supplementary adverb "though" from the preceding main clause ("Such interpretations are ultimately speculative") and uses a semicolon to join the next main clause ("the object’s...makeup") to the rest of the sentence. Further, placing the semicolon after "though" indicates that the information in the preceding main clause (interpretations of an outer solar system object’s composition based on its color are ultimately speculative) is a qualification of the information in the previous sentence (the composition of an outer solar system object is suggested by its color).

Choice A is incorrect because it fails to mark the boundary between the two main clauses with appropriate punctuation. Choice C is incorrect because placing the semicolon after "speculative" illogically indicates that the information in the next main clause ("the object’s....makeup") is a qualification of the information in the previous clause ("Such...speculative"). Choice D is incorrect because it results in a comma splice. Commas can’t be used in this way to punctuate a supplementary word or phrase between two main clauses.

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	Hard

Question

For scientists to produce new iron nanoparticles of a specific size or strength, they must first be able to monitor reactions between oxygen and existing iron nanoparticles at a near-atomic level of detail. Fortunately, chemistry _____ and his colleagues at Temple University recently developed a new approach that does just that.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. professor Yugang Sun
- B. professor Yugang Sun,
- C. professor, Yugang Sun,
- D. professor, Yugang Sun

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer. The convention being tested is the use of punctuation between titles and proper nouns. No punctuation is needed between the proper noun “Yugang Sun” and the title that describes Sun, “chemistry professor.” Furthermore, no punctuation is needed after “Sun” because “chemistry professor Yugang Sun and his colleagues at Temple University” functions as the coordinated subject of the sentence, and together Sun and colleagues performed the action of developing a new approach to producing iron nanoparticles.

Choice B is incorrect because no punctuation is needed between the proper noun “Yugang Sun” and the coordinated noun phrase “and his colleagues at Temple University.” Choice C is incorrect because no punctuation is needed before or after the proper noun “Yugang Sun.” Setting off the professor’s name with commas suggests that it could be removed without affecting the coherence of the sentence, which isn’t the case. Choice D is incorrect because no punctuation is needed between the title “chemistry professor” and the proper noun “Yugang Sun.”

Question ID: 155239cf

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	Easy

Question

By analyzing ice cores from Greenland and Antarctica, a research team at Sweden’s Lund University discovered evidence of a solar storm that occurred 9,200 years ago. Scientists had previously thought the Sun to be in a relatively “quiet” phase at that _____ the Lund team’s finding suggests otherwise.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. time but
- B. time, but
- C. time,
- D. time

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer. The convention being tested is the coordination of main clauses within a sentence. This choice correctly uses a comma and the coordinating conjunction "but" to join the first main clause ("Scientists...time") and the second main clause ("the Lund...otherwise").

Choice A is incorrect because when coordinating two longer main clauses such as these, it’s conventional to use a comma before the coordinating conjunction. Choice C is incorrect because it results in a comma splice. Without a conjunction following it, a comma can’t be used in this way to join two main clauses. Choice D is incorrect because it results in a run-on sentence. The two main clauses are fused without punctuation and/or a conjunction.

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	Medium

Question

Key-value pairs are an important aspect of JavaScript Object Notation (JSON), an electronic file format for storing and transmitting data. Keys function as labels, while values contain the actual information. In a JSON file storing data about fire belly _____ instance, you could encounter a key such as “species” with the associated value of “*Cynops orientalis*.”

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. newts. For
- B. newts, for
- C. newts: for
- D. newts; for

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer. The convention being tested is the use of punctuation within a sentence. The comma after “newts” pairs with the comma after “instance” to separate the supplementary element “for instance” from the rest of the sentence. The supplementary element appears between the prepositional phrase (“In...newts”) and the main clause of the sentence (“you...*orientalis*”) and signals that the sentence is presenting an example of how keys and values function in JSON files.

Choice A is incorrect because it results in a sentence fragment (“In a JSON file storing data about fire belly newts”). Choice C is incorrect because a colon can’t be paired with a comma in this way to separate the supplementary element “for instance” from the rest of the sentence. Choice D is incorrect because a semicolon can’t be paired with a comma in this way to separate the supplementary element “for instance” from the rest of the sentence.

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	Medium

Question

That Chaucer’s *Canterbury Tales* inspired imitators is evident from the existence of three near-contemporary “continuations” of the collection: *The Siege of Thebes*, which purports to be a new tale told during the pilgrims’ _____ *The Tale of Beryn*, which depicts the pilgrims as tourists; and *The Ploughman’s Tale*, which features a minor character from the original work.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. return.
- B. return
- C. return;
- D. return,

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer. The convention being tested is the punctuation of elements in a complex series. It’s conventional to use a semicolon to separate items in a complex series with internal punctuation, and in this choice, the semicolon after “return” is conventionally used to separate the first item (“*The Siege of Thebes*...return”) and the second item (“*The Tale of Beryn*...tourists”) in the series of tales. Moreover, the semicolon after “return” matches the semicolon used later to separate the second item and the third item (“and *The Ploughman’s Tale*...work”) in the series.

Choice A is incorrect because placing a period after “return” results in a rhetorically unacceptable sentence fragment beginning with “*The Tale of Beryn*.” Choice B is incorrect because it fails to use appropriate punctuation to separate the first item and the second item in the complex series. Choice D is incorrect because a comma after “return” doesn’t match the semicolon used later to separate the second and third items in the series.

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	Easy

Question

Emperor penguins don’t waddle out of the ocean. They launch themselves at such a high speed that they travel up to two meters before landing. How _____. A layer of microbubbles on their plumage reduces friction as the penguins speed to the surface.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. they are able to move so fast!
- B. are they able to move so fast.
- C. they are able to move so fast.
- D. are they able to move so fast?

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. The convention being tested is end-of-sentence punctuation. This choice correctly uses a question mark to punctuate the interrogative sentence “how are they able to move so fast?” The interrogative sentence asks a direct question, and the next sentence answers it.

Choice A is incorrect because the context requires an interrogative sentence. The exclamative sentence “how they are able to move so fast!” emphasizes the penguin’s high rate of speed, but it doesn’t set up the next sentence’s explanation of how the penguins achieve such speeds.

Choice B is incorrect because a period can’t be used in this way to punctuate an interrogative sentence. Choice C is incorrect because the context requires an interrogative sentence. The exclamative sentence “how they are able to move so fast” emphasizes the penguin’s high rate of speed, but it doesn’t set up the next sentence’s explanation of how the penguins achieve such speeds.

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	Medium

Question

Beatrix Potter is perhaps best known for writing and illustrating children’s books such as *The Tale of Peter Rabbit* (1902), but she also dedicated herself to mycology, the study of _____ more than 350 paintings of the fungal species she observed in nature and submitting her research on spore germination to the Linnean Society of London.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. fungi; producing
- B. fungi. Producing
- C. fungi producing
- D. fungi, producing

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. The convention being tested is punctuation use between two supplementary phrases following the coordinate clause (“but she...mycology”). This choice correctly uses a comma to mark the boundary between the supplementary noun phrase (“the study of fungi”) that defines the term “mycology” and the supplementary participial phrase (“producing...London”) that provides additional information about the extent to which Potter dedicated herself to mycology.

Choice A is incorrect because a semicolon can’t be used in this way to join two supplementary phrases following a coordinate clause. Choice B is incorrect because it results in a rhetorically unacceptable sentence fragment beginning with “producing.” Choice C is incorrect. The lack of punctuation results in a sentence that illogically suggests that the study of fungi is producing more than 350 paintings.

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	Hard

Question

Philosopher Peter Kivy was a leading figure in musical _____ evidenced by his belief that instead of evoking particular emotions, such as sadness or joy, compositions elicit a listener's emotional response to the structure and artistry of the music itself, Kivy's approach to the study of music was decidedly formalist.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. aesthetics as
- B. aesthetics and as
- C. aesthetics, as
- D. aesthetics. As

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. The convention being tested is punctuation use between sentences. In this choice, the period is used correctly to mark the boundary between one sentence ("Philosopher...aesthetics") and another ("As...formalist"). The long adverbial element "as evidenced...itself" modifies the content in the following clause to support the claim that Kivy's approach was formalist.

Choice A is incorrect because it results in a run-on sentence. The sentences ("Philosopher...aesthetics" and "As...formalist") are fused without punctuation and/or a conjunction. Choice B is incorrect. Without a comma preceding it, the conjunction "and" can't be used in this way to join sentences. Choice C is incorrect because it results in a comma splice. A comma can't be used in this way to mark the boundary between sentences.

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	Hard

Question

Using natural debris, such as dried _____ such as plastic bags; and more traditional art supplies, such as tree glue, Ghanaian artist Ed Franklin Gavua creates his striking Yiiiiikakaii African masks, which he hopes can help viewers rethink how waste is used in their communities.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. leaves, man-made trash:
- B. leaves; man-made trash,
- C. leaves, man-made trash,
- D. leaves; man-made trash;

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer. The convention being tested is the punctuation of elements in a complex series. It’s conventional to use a semicolon to separate items in a complex series with internal punctuation, and in this choice, the semicolon after "leaves" is conventionally used to separate the first item ("natural debris, such as dried leaves") and the second item ("man-made trash, such as plastic bags") in the series of materials used by Gavua. Further, the comma after "trash" correctly separates the noun phrase "man-made trash" from the supplementary phrase ("such as plastic bags") that describes it.

Choice A is incorrect because a comma after "leaves" doesn’t match the semicolon used later to separate the second and third items in the series ("man-made...bags" and "and...glue"). Additionally, it’s not conventional to use a colon in this way to separate a supplementary phrase ("such as plastic bags") from the noun phrase it modifies ("man-made trash"). Choice C is incorrect because a comma after "leaves" doesn’t match the semicolon used later to separate the second and third items in the series ("man-made...bags" and "and...glue"). Choice D is incorrect because it’s not conventional to use a semicolon in this way to separate a supplementary phrase ("such as plastic bags") from the noun phrase it modifies ("man-made trash").

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Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	Hard

Question

In the 1950s, novel audio technologies allowed the addition of another instrument to jazz and swing _____ relatively quiet instrument, its full range of sound was finally audible alongside the blaring brass instruments of the time, allowing flautists like Bennie Maupin and Bobbi Humphrey to perform with other jazz greats.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. music, the flute, a
- B. music. The flute, a
- C. music; the flute, a
- D. music: the flute. A

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. The convention being tested is the use of punctuation within and between sentences. In this choice, the colon correctly introduces the name of the instrument (the flute) that novel audio technologies allowed to be added to jazz and swing. In addition, the period is used to correctly mark the boundary between one sentence ("In...flute") and another ("A relatively...greats").

Choice A is incorrect because it results in a comma splice. A comma can't be used in this way to join two main clauses ("In...quiet instrument" and "its...greats"). Choice B is incorrect. In standard English, it's unconventional to form a sentence in this way with two uncoordinated subjects ("the flute" and "its full range of sound"), and the lack of a clear main subject results in an awkwardly constructed and confusing sentence. Choice C is incorrect. In standard English, it's unconventional to form an independent clause in this way with two uncoordinated subjects ("the flute" and "its full range of sound"), and the lack of a clear main subject results in an awkwardly constructed and confusing clause.

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	Hard

Question

On March 23, 2021, a gust of wind wreaked havoc on global trade. *Ever Given*, an international shipping container vessel, became lodged in Egypt's Suez Canal, a major shipping route between Europe and Asia. The vessel took six days to _____ it's as heavy as two thousand blue whales when fully loaded.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. dislodge in part due to its sheer size,
- B. dislodge, in part due to its sheer size:
- C. dislodge, in part due to its sheer size,
- D. dislodge, in part, due to its sheer size

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer. The convention being tested is punctuation between main clauses and a supplementary element. This choice correctly uses a comma to mark the boundary between the main clause ("The vessel took six days to dislodge") and the supplementary element ("in part due to its sheer size") that provides additional information on why the vessel was difficult to dislodge. Additionally, this choice correctly uses a colon to introduce another main clause that describes the vessel's size ("it's as heavy as two thousand blue whales when fully loaded").

Choice A is incorrect because it results in a comma splice. A comma can't be used in this way to mark the boundary between two main clauses ("The vessel...size" and "it's...loaded"). Additionally, it fails to mark the boundary between the main clause ("The vessel took six days to dislodge") and the supplementary element ("in part due to its sheer size"). Choice C is incorrect because it results in a comma splice. A comma can't be used in this way to mark the boundary between two main clauses ("The vessel...size" and "it's...loaded"). Choice D is incorrect because it results in a run-on sentence. The two main clauses ("The vessel...size" and "it's...loaded") are fused without punctuation and/or a conjunction.